DR. NAFEESA AHMED: REDEFINING EDUCATIONAL LEADERSHIP WITH PURPOSE, PASSION AND POSSIBILITY

"Leadership is not about preserving institutions as they are; it is about preparing them for the future while staying true to the values that built them." **This philosophy defines the journey of Dr. Nafeesa Ahmed, Vice Chairperson of the Presidency Group of Institutions, one of India's most respected educational institutions.**

At a time when education is being reshaped by technology, changing aspirations, and global perspectives, Dr. Nafeesa Ahmed represents a new generation of women leaders who are redefining what leadership looks like. She seamlessly blends tradition with innovation, strategy with empathy, and institutional excellence with a deeply human approach to leadership.

As Vice Chairperson of the Presidency Group of Institutions, she is responsible for guiding one of India's largest education ecosystems, overseeing multiple campuses, thousands of students, educators, and support staff. Yet, beyond the titles and responsibilities lies a leader who believes that the true measure of success is not merely the number of institutions built, but the number of lives transformed.

Carrying Forward a Legacy While Creating Her Own

For many second-generation leaders, the greatest challenge is stepping out of an established legacy while honouring it. Dr. Nafeesa Ahmed has accomplished precisely that.

Inspired by the vision of her father, **Dr. Nissar Ahmed,** Founder and Chairman of the Presidency Group, she embraced stewardship over inheritance. Rather than simply preserving what already existed, she has thoughtfully reimagined it for a new era.

Under her leadership, the Presidency Group has strengthened its focus on holistic education, global exposure, innovation-driven learning, sustainability, and future-ready curricula. She has championed experiential learning, technology integration, student wellbeing, international collaborations, and continuous curriculum renewal, ensuring that Presidency remains relevant in an increasingly dynamic educational landscape.

Her strength lies in understanding that educational excellence is never static. Schools must evolve as society evolves.

A Leader Who Never Stopped Learning

One of the defining characteristics of Dr. Nafeesa Ahmed's journey is her unwavering commitment to lifelong learning.

Recently, she completed the prestigious **INSEAD Leadership Programme for Senior Executives,** one of the world's most respected executive leadership programmes. Learning alongside global business leaders, entrepreneurs, and policymakers expanded her perspective on organisational transformation, innovation, and leadership in a rapidly changing world.

Instead of viewing education only through an academic lens, the programme strengthened her understanding of building agile institutions capable of responding to future challenges.

Her academic journey reflects the same curiosity and commitment to excellence. She holds degrees in Business Management, International Management, English Literature, and a Bachelor of Education from IGNOU. She has further enhanced her expertise through executive programmes at Harvard University and the Wharton School.

Her Ph.D. in Education Management from ESRDS, France, conferred at the House of Lords in London, reflects a rare blend of academic scholarship and practical leadership.

For Dr. Nafeesa Ahmed, learning has never been a milestone—it is a continuous journey.

Building Institutions Through People

While infrastructure, technology, and academic results often define educational success, Dr. Nafeesa Ahmed believes institutions are ultimately built by people.

Her leadership philosophy places teachers at the heart of transformation.

Recognising that empowered educators create empowered students, she has invested significantly in faculty development through continuous professional learning, international exposure, leadership training, pedagogical innovation, and mentoring initiatives.

She encourages teachers not merely to deliver lessons but to become facilitators of curiosity, creativity, and critical thinking.

Within the Presidency Group, leadership is intentionally distributed rather than concentrated. Department heads, school leaders, coordinators, and faculty members are encouraged to take ownership, innovate confidently, and contribute meaningfully to institutional growth.

This culture of trust has strengthened collaboration while creating resilient institutions capable of adapting to change.

Entrepreneurial Thinking in Education

One of Dr. Nafeesa Ahmed's most significant contributions has been bringing entrepreneurial thinking into mainstream education.

She believes today's students must graduate not only with academic knowledge but with the confidence to create opportunities, solve problems, and lead change.

Under her leadership, innovation labs, startup mentoring, industry partnerships, entrepreneurship initiatives, and experiential learning programmes have become integral components of the educational experience.

Students are encouraged to think independently, experiment fearlessly, embrace failure as learning, and develop solutions that address real-world challenges.

